

SHAILESH RAVAL



The Tale of Five Patels

AHMEDABAD Will the Leuva Patels, who constitute over 13 per cent of the vote bank in Gujarat, go against Chief Minister Narendra Modi in the state polls due in December? And if they do, how many will they take with them? These were the questions being asked last week as BJP high command suspended five party MLAs—Gordhan Zadaphia, Dhiru Gajera, Balu Tanti, Bechar Bhadani and Bavku Unghad—for anti-party activities.

The quintet has been trying to cobble an anti-

Modi Patel coalition in the state. The last straw came when Gajera said that in order to teach “Duryodhana Modi” and “Dhrithrashtra L.K. Advani” a lesson, they would vote for Pratibha Patel as President instead of Bhairon Singh Shekhawat. The five are followers of Keshubhai Patel who has maintained a studied silence on the issue so far. They have been speaking against Modi ever since he displaced Keshubhai in 2001. Though some BJP leaders fear the Leuva Patel community might go

DIFFERENT STROKES: Keshubhai and Modi

against Modi, the actual situation may not be so bad. The anti-Patel factor has worked in the past only when the target has been a Kshatriya; Modi is a Teli and an OBC by caste. Hence large sections of the upwardly mobile and now urbanised Leuva Patel community might just not be taken in by the rebel MLAs’ campaign.

Also, the anti-Patel social coalition that exists particularly in Patel-dominated villages can only be suppressed by Hindutva rhetoric. Hence, if the Leuva Patel factor works against Modi, it might trigger a backlash from other castes in Modi’s favour.

But the chief minister is unperturbed. He is sitting pretty, confident that his Hindutva image and his development work stand him in good stead. Says a Modi aide, “He just has to say that he is an Indian first and then a member of any caste and things go in his favour.” This time around, it might not be so easy though.

by Uday Mahurkar

SIGNPOSTS

JOINED: The Indian Cricket League, ex-West Indies captain **Brian Lara**, becoming the first big-name signing up for the break-away faction of the BCCI.

CHARGED: Shankaracharya of Kanchi’s Kamakoti Peetham **Sri Jayendra Saraswati** with attempt to murder and criminal



conspiracy, for allegedly assaulting an auditor of the Mutt in 2002 who had com-

plained about misappropriation of temple funds.

WON: By **Rohan Bopanna** and Pakistan’s Aisam-ul-Haq Qureshi, the doubles title at the \$25,000 ATP Challenger in Manchester, England, beating Jesse Huta Galung of The Netherlands and Michael Ryderstedt of Sweden 4-6, 6-3, 10-5.

OPENED: By the **Indian Air Force**, five international air routes for civilian overflights along with all its airfields for joint operational use.

VIS-A-VIS MAYAWATI Uttar Pradesh chief minister **versus** AMITABH BACHCHAN actor

“When he is not the owner of the land (in Barabanki), how can he donate it?”



SAURABH SINGH

“This is my land and I shall do whatever I want to do with it.”

EPILOGUE: Whether one keeps something or donates, political vendetta is sure to land anybody in trouble.